

Chapter 12

Leading the Middle Stage of a Group

The most important stage of a group is the middle or working stage, because this is when the members should be working, learning, and deriving maximum benefit from being in a group. In the middle stage, members discuss, share, and work on problems or tasks. The emphasis in this chapter will be on groups that meet for a number of sessions; however, the information will also be useful for groups that meet only once or twice, because they will also have a middle stage.

In this chapter, we discuss the planning and assessment tasks that leaders face during the working stage as well as some essential leadership techniques and activities that can help. We also offer outlines for covering common topics, discuss the mistakes that leaders often make during the middle sessions, and present strategies useful to certain types of groups. In the two chapters following this one, we continue the discussion of leading middle sessions, focusing on the use of counseling theories and on conducting counseling and therapy in groups.

Planning and Assessment

During the middle stage, the leader must decide how much planning is needed based on the purpose of the group, the personalities and needs of the members, and the levels of trust, interest, and commitment. Some leaders plan the entire series of sessions before the group begins and fail to modify those plans according to the evolution of the group. *It is important to realize that session plans conceived*

well in advance or plans from a group that worked for you last year may not work for the current situation.

Assessing the Benefits

Periodically during the middle stage, the leader will want to assess the group's value to its members and make adjustments if the group is not beneficial. To assess the benefits of the group, the leader can use any of the following activities:

- Conduct a 1–10 round on how valuable the group has been. The leader would follow up with a discussion of the ratings.
- Conduct a comment round in which the leader asks each member to comment on the value of the group.
- Initiate a discussion of the value of the group by saying something like, "For the next half hour or so, I'd like people to comment on how this group is being helpful." This differs from a round in that not everyone necessarily comments, and the discussion will be more extensive.
- Have members review each topic discussed. Getting members to comment on what has stood out to them can help the leader evaluate the effectiveness of the group experience. If the members fail to recall the main points or if they have little to say, there is a good chance the group is not as beneficial as it could be.
- Ask members to write for 5 to 10 minutes on what they have gained from the group up to this point. Good stimulus questions include the following:

  1. How is this group helping you?
  2. What activities are most beneficial to you?
  3. How do you feel about the group?
  4. What things do you dislike about the group?
  5. What would make the group better for you?

- Leaders can have members write at the end of the session and leave what they write, or leaders can assign out-of-group projects to be brought in at the next meeting or e-mailed.

By engaging in one of the preceding activities, the leader should have a better understanding of how the members feel the group is benefiting them, which in turn will help improve future sessions. Although it is the leader's responsibility to try to make the group a meaningful experience for everyone, it is important to remember that this is not always possible. Some individuals may lack the personal resources, such as attention span or communication skills, to benefit from certain kinds of groups. Likewise, the leader should not be overwhelmed or feel defensive if members have various criticisms. It is important that leaders remember that not everyone will always like everything that takes place in the group.

Assessing Members' Interest and Commitment

During the middle stage, leaders should also assess members' interest and commitment levels. To assess the interest and commitment of the members, the leader observes the frequency of absences and late arrivals, which is often one indication. Also, the leader observes the energy throughout the session. The leader looks for patterns of disinterest over a period of two or three sessions rather than in a single session, because outside stresses and concerns can easily affect a member's level of commitment for any given session.

When the members' interest seems to be declining, the leader may first want to assess whether the loss of interest applies to everyone or just a few of the members. When only a few members have lost interest, the leader will want to try to understand why. It may be that members' interest levels were low from the beginning because they were forced to be in the group. Members may also not be committed to the group because they don't find the content interesting, don't feel their needs are being met, and aren't ready to make changes in their lives. No matter what the reason, the leader will want to try to remedy the situation, possibly by using one of the following options.

If most members have lost interest, the leader can:

- Decide that the group has served its purpose and end the group
- Change the format of the group to generate new interest and commitment
- Bring up the issue for discussion in the group

If a few members have lost interest, the leader can:

- Bring up the issue with the entire group, keeping in mind that there will be differences of opinion. The discussion may prove helpful in clarifying the purpose of the group and in revealing why certain members are not interested. Depending on what is said, the leader may or may not be able to make changes that will increase some members' interest.
- Meet with those whose interest seems low and talk to them about how they could be more involved. If they are no longer committed to the group, the leader may choose to ask them not to return. This option should not be used often, but it should be considered, because no group can go well when a number of members lack commitment to its purpose.
- Give members permission to drop out of the group. This can be done in two ways: (1) mention that some may want to drop out and this would be a good time to do so, or (2) have a closing session for the current group, letting members know they have the option of requesting to be in a second group that is starting immediately.

Assessing Each Member's Participation

During the middle sessions of any group, the leader will want to consider each member's frequency and style of participation. Although there is no "correct" way to participate in the group, active, verbal participation is usually better for most members than merely observing or occasionally commenting. As a rule, it is desirable to try to get quiet members to share their thoughts and feelings, in the hope that they will become more comfortable sharing in the group. There will be times when getting members to share more is either not possible or not desirable.

A related member-participation problem arises when the leader feels that members are making only superficial comments. To change the level of participation, the leader can use a variety of skills and techniques:

- He can change his voice so that it reflects a quiet, deliberate tone and indicates a more serious mood, to which members will tend to respond more seriously.
- She can mention her observation of what is happening and suggest that the level of participation change. She can use the depth chart as a visual tool, showing that the group is not going below 7 with any discussion.
- He can shift to an exercise or activity that has the potential for generating more serious discussion.
- She can shift to a topic that will generate more personal discussion.

Assessing Members' Trust Level and Group Cohesion

During the working stage, the leader needs to be aware of the level of trust that the members are feeling. The "storming" stage that many writers describe has to do with the development of trust and cohesion. When the leader does not pay enough attention to the continued development of trust, it may deteriorate and lead to members feeling uncomfortable in the group. If a leader finds herself in a situation in which the group's trust level is low, she will want to focus on the issue of trust, either by bringing it up for discussion or by using one of the several trust exercises, such as the trust walk.

Assessing How Much to Focus on Content and How Much to Focus on Process

During the working stage, the leader should pay attention to both group content and group process and should constantly decide what the proper balance should be between the two. It is important to mention this because no matter what the purpose, there will be times when focusing on process is very important and

necessary. A common mistake made by leaders is to ignore the process and just focus on content. Not focusing on process can lead to a very superficial group in which dynamics exist such as members dominating the group; members not trusting each other; or members feeling attacked, judged, or inferior. If the leader wants the group to be maximally beneficial, he has to monitor group dynamics, especially if they are negative.

Screening Out Members

There will be times when a leader will have to make the difficult choice of asking a member to leave the group. This should be done only after numerous attempts have been made to help the difficult member become a cooperative group member. We know of many situations where a group has been "sacrificed" because the leader was afraid to ask a member to leave the group.

Some leaders want the group members to decide whether another member should be asked to leave, and in some situations, this may be a good idea. However, most of the time the leader should make the decision because the leader is in the best position to decide whether the member is interfering with the development of the group. *Always keep in mind that it is your responsibility to try to make sure that a group has the proper membership composition so that it can be maximally beneficial.*

Dealing with Breach of Confidentiality

There will be times when a breach of confidentiality by one or more members in the group occurs. This obviously is a situation that must be given much thought. Before anything is done, the leader should talk to the member who breached confidentiality to get some idea as to what happened and why. If the leader finds out that the occurrence was accidental and innocent, then the leader may consider letting the member remain in the group. Before deciding, the leader definitely must get a sense of how the other members feel about having the member involved in future sessions. This can be done at the start of the next session with either the member present or not present. Having the member stay depends on the situation, the other members, and the member who breached confidentiality. If the member stays, he could be attacked by some or all of the other members (especially in groups of teenagers) and not be able to handle it, or he may benefit greatly from the feedback and comments of the other members. The leader has to gauge what she thinks is the best approach for helping the group and the member. There are no set answers for this type of situation except to give it much thought and, if possible, consult with colleagues to get their input and suggestions.

If the breach of confidentiality occurred out of anger, revenge, or idle gossip, then the leader may feel the member should not be allowed to remain in the group. In this case, the leader would need to tell the member he cannot

return to the group and then process with him any feelings he has. If at all possible, the leader would want to turn the situation into a learning experience for the member and for the group when it meets the next time.

One of the most difficult situations that can occur around breach of confidentiality is when the leader, due to agency policy, does not have the option to ask a member to leave the group. The leader must then decide the best way to minimize the effects of having the member remain in the group. Needless to say, this is not a good situation, but it does occur in certain settings.

Leadership Skills and Techniques for the Middle Sessions

Several skills and techniques are especially appropriate for the middle sessions. To make the group a valuable and worthwhile experience, the most important skills to remember are cutting off; drawing out; and holding, shifting, and deepening the focus; all of which have been discussed in earlier chapters. In this section, we elaborate on some additional skills that are valuable when leading middle sessions. Because we have already mentioned these in previous chapters, our descriptions are brief.

1. Using progress reports
2. Introducing topics for discussion
3. Stimulating members' thoughts
4. Varying the format
5. Changing leadership style, if warranted
6. Changing the structure of the group, if warranted
7. Using voice to get members to think
8. Using outside materials and assignments
9. Meeting with members individually
10. Informing members in advance when the group is ending

Using Progress Reports

In many groups, members often share aspects of their lives that need to be followed up on during the next session. An excellent way to do this is by starting each session with progress reports from various members. Not only is this helpful to the members who share their progress, but this kind of sharing also helps build cohesion in the group. Some leaders make the mistake of letting progress reports take up too much time, when 5 to 10 minutes should be sufficient.

LEADER: Why don't we start? I think it would be good to get updates on what has happened since last session. I recall that a number of you said you were working on some significant issues. How was the week? Let's spend 5 minutes or so catching up with what happened.

Introducing Topics for Discussion

To keep interest high, the leader must continually be listening for new slants or themes as members discuss various subjects. When the leader sees that the energy is starting to wane, he will want to introduce new topics for discussion. The leader can accomplish this by spinning off from what has been said—that is, by shifting the focus to a topic that has emerged from the ongoing discussion.

■ EXAMPLES

The members have been discussing communication with their spouses and how to handle trouble areas, such as children, in-laws, and money.

JANE: We do okay in most of these areas. Money problems we now seem to have under control. We still have problems over sex and religion. We cannot discuss those at all. I really do feel at a loss. Last week was really a bad scene. He refused to talk about why we've not had sex in over a month. He walked away and slammed the door! But I guess all couples have some areas of conflict. I know my parents fought about many different things.

LEADER: Let's take a look at communication with regard to sex. For many couples, this is a major source of friction. Anyone want to comment?

In this example, the leader took a topic that one of the members mentioned and introduced it to the group by making a brief comment.

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Stimulating Members' Thoughts

Leaders must be prepared to stimulate discussion because members may not always be ready to share their ideas. To stimulate the group, leaders may use exercises and various activities. The leader may also use some general questions or comments that encourage and facilitate sharing and discussion. Sometimes all the leader needs to do is ask a general question. At other times, the leader will want to make a brief statement and then ask a question. Many leaders use questions only and do not realize the value of sometimes prefacing their questions with a brief comment. Below are a few examples of ways to stimulate thought:

- Many of you seem to be deep in thought. What are the one or two points that stood out to you?

- The feelings that Zeda is sharing are quite common, and often people don't express these feelings. I appreciate Zeda's honesty. We'll come back to her in a minute, but first, let me ask, does anyone else have similar feelings?
- I think some of you would disagree with what has been said and it is important that you share your thoughts. Would anyone like to react or comment?
- In listening to the comments, I felt that many of you were holding back your true feelings. For this group to be truly helpful, I urge you to share how you really feel. *(Pause)* Any comments on what I just said?

Varying the Format

The leader should always consider the format of the group and whether it needs to change. In some groups, members seem to prefer and benefit from the same format. The leader will want to vary the format only when she sees that the group members are bored with the same agenda. If the leader senses that changing the format would be beneficial, she can decide or have the group decide on how to spend time so that the sessions are more interesting and helpful.

LEADER: It seems to me that we may want to change how we have been doing group. There are many excellent topics that we could cover, but we mostly spend time with different people's issues. It does seem that members are getting help, but my question to you is, do you want to devote the whole time to members' issues that sometimes seem to be repetitious, or do you want me to think of some group exercises that would trigger other issues?

DAX: I like it the way it is.

MILLIE: I think the group could use some new things. I am kind of bored.

TRAY: Can we do both? I would like to know that I can come here and talk about my problems, but group exercises sound good to me.



GROUP COUNSELING SKILLS: Varying the Format

View again video 8.7. In this video, the leader decides to vary the format and conduct a movement exercise.

Changing Leadership Style, if Warranted

Sometimes during the middle stage of the group, the leader may feel there is a need to change the style of leadership. Often, this takes the form of doing less

leading and encouraging the members to take more responsibility. The leader has members do most of the cutting off, drawing out, and generating topics for discussion. Other situations may dictate that the leader take a more active role, especially if the group has evolved into a therapy group.

Changing the Structure of the Group, if Warranted

There may be times during the middle stage of the group that the leader will see the need for a change in structure. Changes may take the form of adding new members, meeting less often, or having an extended meeting, perhaps over a weekend. Before deciding on any of these changes, the leader would want to introduce the idea for discussion.

In certain kinds of groups, some members want one purpose for the group, whereas others will want the group to serve an entirely different purpose. When members want two or more different structures or purposes, a difficult situation exists. Each situation is unique, so the solution is not always the same. The following are options for dealing with such a situation.

- The leader can divide the group into two subgroups. (This is often not possible because of size, time considerations, and so on, but it is an option to be considered.)
- The leader can divide the time in half—that is, half the time the group will do one thing, and half the time it will do another. (This will work only if the members can be cooperative when the group is doing the half in which they are not as interested.)
- The leader can let the members decide how to handle their differences of opinion about what the group should be doing.
- The leader can inform the group that there are no options, because the group has a specific purpose to which they must adhere.

If you find yourself in this situation and you take some action, it is important to realize that some members may be upset with you or with the group, creating a dynamic that will need to be monitored.

Using Voice to Get Members to Think

As mentioned in Chapter 6 on Basic Skills for Group Leaders, the leader's voice can often serve to both energize and change the "tone" of the group. Leaders should always be aware of the effectiveness of their voice in accomplishing the goals of the group. In particular, in certain kinds of groups, they may use their voice to get members to think more complexly about an issue. This can sometimes be accomplished by slowing their speech, deepening their tone, and pausing before encouraging a response to give members time to reflect. This process can take the members to a deeper level.



GROUP COUNSELING SKILLS: Using Voice

Go to video 14.3 and listen carefully to how the leader uses his voice to get members to go more deeply into themselves.

Using Outside Materials and Assignments

Some groups lend themselves to outside assignments. These assignments can be in the form of reading assignments, writing assignments, or *doing* assignments. By *doing*, we mean such things as calling someone, talking to a certain number of people, signing up for some kind of lessons, varying the morning routine, and so forth. For many groups, assigned outside reading, TV shows, and other forms of outside work can serve as a way of keeping members involved in the group between sessions. Also, assignments can serve as a stimulus for discussion for the next group meeting.

One useful assignment is to have each member write an encouraging letter to herself that she brings to the group with a self-addressed, stamped envelope. The members leave their letters and the leader mails them in between sessions so each member gets a letter from him- or herself during the period between sessions if the group meets only twice a month. The leader may choose to read the letters and make some additional comments or just mail the letters, depending on what seems more beneficial.

Meeting with Members Individually

In certain kinds of groups, during the middle stage, the leader may want to meet with some or all the members individually to discuss feelings about the group. Such a meeting gives the member a chance to share his opinions and reactions to the group with the leader. It also gives the leader a chance to discuss various issues with the member without the time constraints and dynamics that exist during a group session. Some experts advocate that meetings of this nature can detract from the group. We have found the opposite to be true, because some members may need the opportunity for some private time. Often these individual meetings help the member to share more in the group. Simply stated, counselors are in the business to be helpful, and we encourage leaders to do whatever they can, within ethical guidelines, to be as helpful as possible.

Informing Members in Advance When the Group Is Ending

Leaders may want to inform members at least 3 to 5 weeks in advance when the group is going to end. Leaders usually determine the ending of a group during the beginning stage, although there will be occasions when no ending time is set.

Even when the ending time is set, it is a good idea for the leader to remind the members that the group will be ending in a few weeks.

Middle-Session Topic Outlines

Too often an important topic is brought up in the group but is not handled very well because the leader was not prepared to discuss the topic. *One of the most important things a leader can do during the middle stage of a group is to think through the different issues that are relevant so that she is prepared to focus on the issues in a meaningful way when they arise.*

We thought it would be helpful to outline the key issues, introductory exercises, and other exercises of topics common to many kinds of groups. We outline four topics: the need for approval, self-esteem, religion, and sex. These were selected from a list of common topics that emerge as focal points during the life of a group. We could have chosen several other topics, such as worry, anger, love relationships, divorce, death, or parents—all are major topics. The purpose of these outlines is to give you some idea of how to think through a given topic. Here we offer ways to focus on each topic and deepen the focus so that the discussion is meaningful. We suggest you use this structure for any major topic that may arise in groups that you are leading. It is important to realize that much thought must be given to the appropriateness of any of the exercises described in these outlines.

Topic 1: The Need for Approval

Key Issues

1. Sources of approval: parents, lover, boss, children, and friends
2. Where the need for approval comes from
3. How people seek approval
4. How strong is the need for approval
5. Positive and negative ways that people seek approval
6. Trusting oneself
7. Dependence/independence
8. Difference between needing and wanting approval
9. How to reduce approval-seeking behavior
10. Use of REBT, TA, and attachment theory to understand need for approval

Possible Introductory Exercises

- Round: How important to you is the approval of others? (1 to 10)
- Dyads: Discuss early experiences in your family. Did you feel you were approved of? How does that affect your current functioning?

- Rounds or dyads: Whose approval do you seek and how do you seek it?
- Written exercise: List people whose approval is important to you. Arrange them in order of importance. Then discuss in dyads, triads, or in the group.
- Sentence completion or rounds:

  If my parents did not approve of me, I would _____.

  If my supervisor/teacher did not approve of me, I would _____.

  If my spouse/lover did not approve of me, I would _____.

  If I sense disapproval, I _____.

Deepening Rounds, Dyads, and Exercises

- Round: The need for approval is a desire, a necessity, or a burden. (Choose one.)
- Written exercise: Make a list of gains and losses resulting from your approval-seeking behavior.
- Dyads: Discuss ways you attempt to gain approval from others and classify each as effective or ineffective.
- Round or movement exercise: Respond with strongly agree, agree, neutral, disagree, or strongly disagree to the following statement: Approval from others is more important to me than self-approval.
- Set up some role-play where members experience disapproval.
- Give feedback to each other (make sure it isn't all positive). Discuss reactions.
- Have members pair up. One stands while shaking a finger, looking very disgustedly at the other, who sits in small chair. Discuss the different reactions, memories, and so on.
- Set up approval situations; then get members to discuss how using REBT and TA can help.

Topic 2: Self-Esteem

Key Issues

1. Definition of self-esteem
2. Sources of self-esteem
3. Raising self-esteem
4. Possibility of changing feelings of self-esteem
5. Parents' role
6. Siblings' and friends' role
7. Spouse's or lover's role

8. School, grades, intelligence, and self-esteem
9. Appearance and self-esteem
10. Sports and self-esteem
11. Work and self-esteem
12. TA and the child ego state
13. REBT, self-talk, and self-esteem
14. Defining winners and losers
15. Guilt, shame, and self-esteem

It is important for anyone leading a group on self-esteem to have a theoretical understanding of self-esteem. We mentioned TA and REBT, but certainly there are other theories that are useful when working with self-esteem. We have had very good results with school-age children using these theories.

Introductory Exercises

- Round: If 10 is liking yourself a whole lot and 1 is hating yourself, what rating would you give yourself?
- Round: What one or two things affect your self-esteem—that is, affect how you feel about yourself?
- Written: Using a 1–10 scale, with 10 being very good, list how you feel about yourself on the following: appearance, intelligence, and personality.
- Written: In a sentence or two, define self-esteem. Then write down your ideas regarding it: Can I change, and if so, how? If not, why not?
- Dyads: Pair up and discuss how you feel about yourself and why.
- Sentence completion: I feel better about myself when _____.
- Sentence completion: I feel bad about myself when _____.

Deepening Rounds, Dyads, and Other Exercises

- Round: What is one thing you need to do to improve how you feel about yourself?
- Round: What negative sentences do you tell yourself that cause you to feel "less than" others?
- Dyads: Pair up and talk about what you were told about yourself by significant others when you were growing up.
- Creative-prop exercise: I want each of you to take a Styrofoam cup and think of it as your self-esteem or self-worth cup. Now I want you to take a pencil and punch holes in the cup, with the holes representing the holes you have in your self-esteem. Many of you have big holes from childhood, parents, school, and various other relationships and incidents. Take a minute or so to think, and then punch your holes.

- Movement: I want everyone to stand and line up side by side, facing me (about 8 feet away). I am going to draw an imaginary line here in front of me that represents your feeling really good about yourself. In a minute, I am going to have you move toward the line to represent where you see yourself. Where you are standing now is feeling very "not okay" about yourself.... On 3, move—ready, 1, 2, 3. (Everyone moves.) What can you do today to help you move closer to this line?

Topic 3: Religion

Key Issues

1. Early messages/parental messages
2. Religious history of members
3. Benefits in your life
4. Restrictions in your life
5. Religion as a personal choice versus a "should"
6. Effects of religion on
   a. guilt
   b. sexual issues
   c. marriage and divorce
   d. abortion/birth control
7. Determinism versus free will
8. Life after death
9. Importance of religion in your life
10. Belief in God

With any discussion of religion, the leader needs to be aware the discussion can become very emotional and heated, which, in most instances, would not be the purpose. Rather, the usual purpose of a discussion about religion is to help members feel comfortable with their beliefs and behavior and to be tolerant of others.

Possible Introductory Rounds and Dyads

- Round: What issues regarding religion would you like to discuss?
- Round: Briefly tell your religious background and where you currently stand with regard to organized religion. (Church member? Nonmember? Nonbeliever?)
- Round: How much influence does religion have in your life? (1 to 10)
- Round: Does religion cause any problems in your life? (yes/no)
- Dyads: Are you bothered by any current issues concerning religion? If not, what were some past issues that bothered you?

- Dyads: Do you profess a particular religion? How do you practice your religion?

These introductory rounds and dyads would be useful to the leader in gathering information about how the members feel about religion. The introductory activities would also get members focused on the topic. The following exercises would be used only when appropriate and usually would not be used as beginning rounds to introduce the topic of religion.

Deepening Rounds, Dyads, and Other Exercises

- Round: If you are currently in a relationship, do you and your partner agree or disagree about religion?
- Dyads or triads: Discuss briefly what is the most disturbing aspect of religion in your life.
- Dyads or round: What do you find the most helpful and the most difficult about your religious beliefs?
- Triads or round: Regarding religious training, what would you do differently with your children than your parents did with you?
- Written exercise: List early messages about religion.
- Set up some relevant role-play situations where religion in some way is causing a problem.
- Respond to the following statements with strongly agree, agree, neutral, disagree, or strongly disagree:

1. Religion is the opiate of the masses.
2. We all have free will.
3. There is life after death.

Topic 4: Sex

Key Issues

1. How you learned about sex
2. Satisfaction with sex life
3. Guilt
4. Early experiences
5. Difficulties and inhibitions regarding sex
6. Preferences, frequency
7. Sex without love
8. Sex and religious beliefs and early messages about sex
9. Communication with partner
10. Orgasm

11. Masturbation, fantasy
12. Extramarital sex
13. Homosexuality

It is important for any leader discussing sex to be clear about the many different issues, because the members probably won't be. Any leader choosing to discuss this topic should not be judgmental and should be tolerant of various sexual attitudes, beliefs, and behaviors. The leader also must be prepared to deal with members' negative reactions to such issues as homosexuality, affairs, or unorthodox sexual practices.

Introductory Exercises

- Round: If 10 is very comfortable, how comfortable are you with discussing sex in this group? (1 to 10)
- Round: If 10 is very important, how much importance do you place on sex in your love relationship? (1 to 10)
- Dyads: What are some issues related to sex that might be discussed in the group? (Have pairs report back to the entire group some topics they discussed.)
- Round: Complete the following sentences:

  I think sex is _____.

  Discussing sex in this group is _____.

  Many of my current feelings about sex come from _____.
- Round: In a word or phrase, how would you describe your present sex life?

Deepening Rounds, Dyads, and Other Exercises

- Reaction sentences: Have members give their reaction in writing, in a round, or by indicating where their opinion would lie along a continuum from strongly agree to strongly disagree to any of the following sentences.

  - Masturbation is a bad thing.
  - It is my obligation to make sure my partner has a satisfying experience.
  - If either partner fails to have an orgasm, the encounter is a failure.
  - Everyone should have sex before marriage.
  - To have a good sexual relationship, you must be in love.
  - Sex is fun.
- Round: I would like to have sex _____ times a week.
- Triads: What is your greatest concern or fear regarding sex?
- Round: Do you have any leftover or current guilt regarding sex? (yes/no). (If there are yeses the leader could ask if the members want to work

on their guilt. Or the leader could introduce a helpful discussion about sex and guilt.)

- Round: In a word or phrase, how would you describe your comfort communicating with a partner when having sex?
- Written exercise: List your expectations in a sexual relationship.
- Round: If my partner had an affair, I would _____.
- Written exercise: Write on a 3-inch by 5-inch card anything pertaining to sex that you would like to talk about. (The exercise is anonymous so that members can write such things as having been sexually abused, having an affair, or having certain sexual fantasies.) The leader would then collect the cards and lead a discussion about the various written comments. (This can be a very powerful and helpful exercise if conducted properly.)

As we said in the beginning of this section, the preceding examples are just some of the key issues and possible exercises for the chosen topics. There are many more exercises that could be outlined. Our intent is to encourage you to think through a topic thoroughly before you lead a group on it. The processing of any of these exercises can take a group to a deeper level.

Middle-Session Leadership Tactics for Specific Groups

In this section, we briefly discuss some additional techniques for education and task groups. In Chapter 13, we discuss skills that are useful for the working stage of growth, support, counseling, and therapy groups.

The Education Group

In the middle stage of an education group, the leader must pay much attention to shifting from giving information, to facilitating discussion, and back to giving more information. This sequencing keeps the group flowing and increases the chances of helping members learn and apply their new knowledge to their lives. The key is to provide enough information and enough sharing and discussion time. Often, beginning leaders lose sight of the experience of being a group and focus too much on providing information, or spend too much time on sharing and don't cover enough information. A true education group will have a good balance of information and interaction.

The Task Group

The task group leader's role during the middle stage is to help members generate options and help them move toward a decision or resolution. Because the task

group involves a group goal rather than individual goals, members may take strong stands on issues. The leader will always want to consider how the members feel about each other and about the task on which they are working. The leader needs to be aware of who the more influential members of the group are and what type of pressure they exert on other members. Also, the leader should be aware of any hidden agendas of the members. In other words, when leading a task group, the leader must watch for many different group dynamics and must be willing to focus on the dynamics if they are interfering with the progress of the group.

Helping Members Generate Ideas and Options The discussion of various options during a task group is sometimes difficult because members become emotionally identified with their own ideas and find it hard to discuss others. Leaders must be able to get members to discuss and exchange ideas in a productive manner. The leader's choice of any of the following strategies depends on the number of members in the group, the kind of goals the group is working toward, the level of agreement among members, and their attitude of cooperation. Brainstorming, the fishbowl, working in small groups, and guided fantasy often prove to be valuable tools for generating options and moving the group to some resolution.

Brainstorming In brainstorming, leaders have members generate as many ideas as possible without regard to practical limitations. The theory behind brainstorming is that people often impose unnecessary limitations on their creativity by assuming constraints that may not exist or that may be possible to change. Once ideas are out in the open, members may come up with creative changes that eliminate the constraints. The basic rule for brainstorming is that no idea is too wild or crazy to be introduced. Because ideas are not evaluated or censored during brainstorming, the members' feelings of defensiveness are reduced. Brainstorming may be done in the entire group or in small groups of three or four. A time limit helps the group stay focused.

Once ideas are brainstormed, overlapping ideas should be eliminated or consolidated. Then the remaining ideas are listed, discussed, and ranked. The leader can then examine several of the better ideas in greater detail with the group and elaborate on them as needed. If the leader uses the brainstorming technique effectively, every member should feel he has had the opportunity to provide some input.

The fishbowl The fishbowl is a technique that a leader can use with a variety of groups; it works especially well with larger groups. The group is divided, with half the members forming an inner circle and the other half, an outer circle. While the inner group discusses an issue or idea, the outer group listens. (People often can listen better when they know they are not going to speak.)

After a given time period, the members switch places, with the new inner group sharing its reactions to the previous discussion. The new inner group may provide constructive criticism or build on the ideas already generated.

Small-group variations Small-group interaction (three or four members to a group) can almost always be useful, in that members have the opportunity to discuss ideas in greater detail and more people get to talk because the group is smaller. Members in small groups may all work on the same task or on different phases of the task. The results of the small-group discussions are then shared in the larger group.

Guided fantasy In a task group, the guided fantasy provides a chance for members to picture, think about, or get a feeling for the outcome of various solutions generated by the group. Also, members may imagine the outcome and then construct what must happen for that outcome to be realized, thus generating various solutions. The following is an example of how a guided fantasy could be used.

■ EXAMPLE

A school counselor is leading a task group of parents. The task is to develop a valuable summer program for school kids in the community. The leader introduces a guided fantasy by saying:

LEADER: *(Using a quiet voice)* At this point, let's think about the outcome of the program you might envision. You might want to close your eyes to try this. Picture an ideal summer day when the program is in place. What are some of the things that are happening? What different things do you see happening and where are they happening? *(Pause)* How many different programs do you see going on? *(Pause)* When you are ready with your ideas, write them down.

This technique helps establish goals, which assists the leader in developing and maintaining the focus.

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Helping Members Move Toward Resolution One of the primary functions of the task group leader is to make sure the group accomplishes its goals. Groups can easily over-discuss an issue but not resolve anything. The skilled leader is always thinking about when and how to help the group accomplish its purpose. If the group is not progressing, one good strategy is to focus the members on the process so that they can become aware of what they are doing.

LEADER: I want to stop you and have you focus on what is happening in the group—not the content but the process. What is going on here that is keeping us from getting more accomplished? Think about what you are doing and what others are doing. I think some of you may even have some strong feelings about what is happening.

Common Mistakes Made During the Middle Sessions

There are numerous mistakes that leaders can make during the middle stage of a group. We discuss the following ones:

- Underleading or overleading the group
- Letting the warm-up phase last too long
- Letting the focus shift too often
- Focusing too long on a member
- Focusing on only one or two members
- Planning only one or two exercises or activities
- Failing to allow time to process an activity
- Choosing uninteresting speakers

Underleading or Overleading the Group

The skilled leader leads to the degree that members gain from his guidance; beginners often mistakenly lead too much or too little. It is possible to overlead—that is, not letting the members have enough input in the group. This is especially detrimental if the leader is focusing on boring, uninteresting, or irrelevant material. On the other hand, it is possible to underlead by turning the group over to the members when they do not understand how to make the group valuable.

Letting the Warm-Up Phase Last Too Long

Workshop participants have shared that too often in the beginning of a session they have let members ramble or focus on irrelevant subjects. The purpose of the warm-up phase is to get the members focused on being in the group. The skilled leader pays close attention and makes sure that the opening does not drift along or head in a direction that is not useful or productive. *Remember, the majority of the time should be spent in the working phase and not the warm-up phase.*

Letting the Focus Shift Too Often

Inexperienced leaders often make the mistake of not holding the focus long enough so that there is impact. In any group situation, it is easy for the focus to move from topic to topic unless the leader holds and deepens the focus. The leader should always be aware of the focus and the depth of the focus. During the working stage, the leader should try to deepen the focus to a level that is meaningful for all or most members.

Focusing Too Long on a Member

It is a mistake to focus too long on a member who does not understand the content of the group. Beginning leaders often cater their group to the confused or slow member, which results in only a marginally valuable group for other members. Here are some of the options available if a member does not seem to understand the content:

- Take time to explain, if it can be done in a relatively short time.
- Have members try to explain or clarify the issue.
- Tell the member you will explain after the session or at a break.
- Tell the member you will meet with him at another time to go over the material.
- Arrange for another member to meet with that member to go over the material.
- Ask another member to go to another part of the room with that member and explain the material. You would not want to do this often because the helpful member would be missing the group.

If a member repeatedly has difficulty understanding material in the group, the leader may ask that person not to remain in the group.

Focusing on Only One or Two Members

If a group has a member who is very talkative or very "needy," some beginning leaders devote week after week focusing on the same member. This practice is easy to fall into because the member seems to need help and the other members all want to be helpful. Leaders also tend to focus on the resistant member. Too often, beginning leaders devote a considerable amount of time trying to help this member while the member rigidly resists. This is often ineffective and wastes much valuable time.

One way to avoid focusing on just one or two members is to use a member assessment technique. The leader can answer the following questions about each member.

- How do you feel about coming to the group?
- What do you need to learn from group?
- What do you need to talk about but is afraid to bring up?
- How much "air time" has each member had in the last few weeks?

By answering these questions for each member, the leader should be able to get some sense of what each member wants or needs from the group. The answers help a great deal in planning the session and also enable the leader to go into a session with a number of possible options and topics.

Planning Only One or Two Exercises or Activities

Another mistake is to plan only one exercise or activity. It is always wise to have backup plans, because there are times when your initial exercise does not generate much energy.

Failing to Allow Time to Process an Activity

It is important to allow enough time to discuss and process any film, guest lecture, or group exercise. Usually the majority of the time should be for sharing and processing rather than for viewing the film, listening to the speaker, or doing the exercise.

Choosing Uninteresting Speakers

For educational groups, when using a guest speaker, the leader should make every effort to ensure that the presentation is interesting and stimulating. It is helpful to meet with the speaker in advance to get a preview of the presentation and to make sure the speaker is clear on the purpose of the group and her presentation.

Concluding Comments

In this chapter, we have outlined skills, techniques, and roles that the leader can use during the middle sessions. When planning the group, the leader should assess what will benefit the group and the members' interest, commitment, and trust levels. When leading the middle sessions, the leader should stimulate thought; introduce new topics; use her voice effectively; and vary the format when necessary. The leader is always thinking about the leadership styles and the structure of the group and should change either of them if necessary. The leader should also keep in mind the kind of group she is leading, because different strategies are needed for the various kinds of groups. Planning for different topics is very important during the middle sessions. By outlining the key issues, introductory exercises and activities, and deepening exercises, leaders will be prepared to lead groups on various topics that are planned or that come up during the session.

Leaders make a number of mistakes during the working stage: underleading or overleading, letting the focus shift too often, focusing too long on a member, focusing on only one or two members, planning only one or two activities, failing to allow time to process an activity, and choosing uninteresting speakers.

■ ACTIVITIES

1. Pick two topics that you think you will cover in a group sometime in your career and then make a list of possible issues, introductory exercises, and deepening activities that cover the topic. Use the middle session topic outlines presented earlier in this chapter as your format.
2. Review the common mistakes. Reflect on a group experience where some mistakes were made. What were those mistakes and what could the leader have done differently?



GROUP COUNSELING SKILLS

1. View again video 10.2 and watch how the leader uses a small chair in a middle session. The leader would know the members enough to assess that the exercise will generate deeper self-exploration.
2. Watch videos 9.2 and 9.3. In each of these, the leader uses an opening round to get a read on the members. Why are these opening rounds helpful during the middle stage of a group?